

The Nation That Failed

India displays its shameful lack of political will to confront the growing threat of radical Islam even as it becomes the easiest target of jihad

■ By S. Prasannarajan

So it is yesterday all over again, and the sameness of the savagery only adds to the legendary Indian sense of sangfroid. Two spirited cities of India, 23 blasts, more than 50 dead, hundreds maimed, and the predictable Day-After theatre of politics feasting on cadavers strewn across the streets of the world's most fatalistic state. This overwhelming banality of horror tells one simple truth: we can take a lot more, we can shed a lot more blood, we have a lot more people to spare... Enterprising jihadists are welcome, and the incentives you get in the great democratic republic where no terrorist worth his nihilistic fantasy is denied the right to kill under an equal opportunity scheme is greater than what you can get anywhere else in the world, may be with the exception of Iraq. It should be now official: India is a dangerous place to be in, unless you are a god's mercenary for whom this wretched

country is the easiest battlefield in the war against infidels or an honourable member of the political class that has already abdicated its responsibility to protect the nation.

The frequency of the attacks and their magnitude say a lot about the jihadist and the victim. The killer is precise; he chooses his target for maximum effect; and he seems to enjoy the kind of freedom that is denied to his brotherhood elsewhere. Ahmedabad comes just two months after Jaipur which was preceded by Hyderabad 2007, Mumbai 2006, Delhi 2005 and the audacious attack on Parliament in the afterglow of 9/11. Come to think of it: the most favoured nation for those who want to invest in jihad is not the United States or Israel any longer. It is India.

Not that Washington and Jerusalem have ceased to be less satanic for jihadists. India does not have the political will or consensus to identify the threat of radical Islam and confront it. It does not have that necessary iron in the nationalist soul to ensure that life is not disposable at the diktat of a coward trapped in the make believe of a scriptural Caliphate.

What we have got is an apparition in funereal white floating in Ahmedabad, mouthing platitudinous inanities as if it is just another routine mission for him in just another death zone. The enormity of our national shame cannot be reduced to the size of the Union Home Minister, but the gentleman is symptomatic of everything that is wrong with those who have the political mandate

This is a Government that denies states like Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan the permission to pass their own anti-terror laws.